

Notes

1. The summary is ascribed to the fifth century A.D. scholar Proclus, who names Agias of Troezen as the author of the *Nostoi*. For a useful discussion, see G. L. Huxley, *Greek Epic Poetry* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1969), Chapter 12.
2. For the story that Helen was in Egypt during the Trojan War, see p. 468.
3. Pindar, *Nemean Odes* 10. 7. Among the many narratives of the legend of Diomedes are those of Vergil (*Aeneid* 11. 243–295) and Ovid (*Metamorphoses* 14. 460–511).
4. Said by Ovid to be “next in shape to swans.” What these birds were can only be surmised.
5. He is also associated with Colophon in Asia Minor.
6. Many attempts have been made to follow the route of Odysseus. See T. Severin, *The Ulysses Voyage: Sea Search for the Odyssey* (London: Hutchinson, 1987). Compare T. Severin, *The Jason Voyage: The Quest for the Golden Fleece* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 1985).
7. According to the conventions of Homeric society, the liaisons with Calypso and Circe did not make Odysseus unfaithful. Cf. Mary R. Lefkowitz, *Women in Greek Myth* (London: Duckworth, 1986), p. 64: “[Penelope] does not demand strict fidelity; neither she nor Helen object to their husbands’ liaisons with other women, so long as they are temporary.” The same point is made by Sarah Pomeroy, *Goddesses, Whores, Wives, and Slaves* (New York: Schocken, 1975), pp. 26–27, and by Marilyn Katz, *Penelope’s Renown* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1991), p. 13.
8. The Greek word *polytropos* (of many ways) means a combination of complexity, intelligence, and being widely traveled.
9. On the island of Lesbos lived Macareus, a son of Aeolus, whose story was told by Euripides in his lost play *Aeolus*. He fell in love with his sister Canace and by her became father of a child. When Aeolus discovered the truth, he sent Canace a sword with which to kill herself, and Macareus also committed suicide.
10. A powerful adaptation of this legend is the Circe episode in James Joyce’s *Ulysses*.
11. The living olive tree and the bed are powerful sexual symbols for a psychoanalytical interpretation.
12. See G. Dimock, “The Name of Odysseus.” *Hudson Review* 9 (1956), pp. 52–70.
13. The soul of Agamemnon describes his murder in the first Underworld scene (*Odyssey* 11. 405–456). The *Odyssey* focuses on Clytemnestra’s deed, not on Agamemnon’s killing of his own daughter, Iphigenia, which motivated Clytemnestra’s revenge.
14. The adventures of Odysseus subsequent to the *Odyssey* were narrated in the lost epic *Telegonia* by Eugammon of Cyrene. It ends with Telegonus conveying Odysseus’ body with Penelope and Telemachus to Circe, who makes them immortal. Telegonus then marries Penelope, and Circe marries Telemachus.
15. The most powerful adaptation of the myth of Odysseus is that of Dante, discussed in Chapter 27 on the companion website. For the many uses of Odysseus made by authors in medieval, Renaissance, and modern times, see the books by Boitani and Stanford listed in the bibliography for this chapter.



Perseus and the Legends of Argos

At that time Argos excelled all the cities in the land that is now called Hellas.

—HERODOTUS, *Histories* 1.1

Argive Hera

Argos was connected in history and in legend with Corinth and Thebes, and the Argive sagas demonstrate the many contacts of Argos with the eastern Mediterranean, notably the Levant and Egypt. While some of the legendary heroes are associated with a particular city of the Mycenaean Argolid (e.g., Heracles with Tiryns, Diomedes with Argos, and Perseus with Mycenae), it is often hard to distinguish between the separate cities. We shall generally use “Argos” to cover the whole Argolid and its cities.

Argos was the greatest center in Greece for the worship of Hera, and the **Heraeum**, the hill where Hera’s sanctuary stood, was the religious center of the whole area. In the Argive saga, the first of men was Phoroneus, who established the kingdom of Argos and decided in favor of Hera in the contest for the land between Poseidon and Hera. In anger, Poseidon dried up the Argive rivers, one of which, Inachus, was the father of Phoroneus. Ever after, the Argive rivers have been short of water.

The richness of the Argive saga can be seen from the opening lines of Pindar’s tenth *Nemean Ode*:

Sing, O Graces, of the city of Danaüs and his fifty daughters on their shining thrones, of Argos, dwelling of Hera, a home fit for the gods; bright is the flame of her brave deeds unnumbered in their excellence. Long is the tale of Perseus and the Gorgon, Medusa; many are the cities of Egypt founded by the wisdom of Epaphus; Hypermnestra kept to the path of virtue and alone did not draw the dagger from its sheath. Fair Athena once made Diomedes divine; in Thebes the earth, struck by Zeus' thunderbolts, received the seer Amphiaraus, the storm cloud of war. Ancient is Argos' excellence in beautiful women; Zeus revealed this truth when he came to Alcmena and to Danaë. (1–11)

The Legend of Perseus

Danaë and Acrisius

Of the heroes of Argos, first in importance, though not in time, is Perseus. His great-grandfather Abas had twin sons, **Proetus** and Acrisius, who quarreled even before their birth.¹ Acrisius, who became king of Argos itself while Proetus ruled Tiryns, had no sons and only one daughter, Danaë; an oracle foretold that her son would kill Acrisius. To keep her from having children, Acrisius shut Danaë up in a brazen underground chamber in his palace, but Zeus loved her and entered the chamber in the form of a shower of gold and lay with her.² Their child was Perseus, and Danaë kept him in the chamber for four years, unknown to Acrisius, until he was discovered from the noise he made while playing. Acrisius refused to believe that Zeus was the child's father and put mother and child into a chest which he set afloat on the sea. The chest floated to the island of **Seriphos**, where the fisherman **Dictys** (whose name means "net") found it and rescued Danaë and Perseus, giving them shelter in his own home.

Polydectes

Now Polydectes, brother of Dictys, was king of Seriphos, and as Perseus grew to manhood, Polydectes fell in love with Danaë, who refused him. He then summoned the leading men of the island to a banquet at which each man had to present him with the gift of a horse. Perseus boasted that he could just as easily give Polydectes the Gorgon's head. Polydectes, eager to get Perseus out of the way, took him at his word and ordered him to perform the task. In despair, Perseus wandered to a lonely part of Seriphos, where Hermes and Athena came to his help with advice. That two gods should assist him is remarkable; Hermes belongs more to the Peloponnese than Athena, and it is very likely he was originally the hero's only supernatural



Danaë and the Brazen Tower, by Edward Burne-Jones (1833–1898); oil on canvas, 1888, 94 × 44½ in. Danaë, in the foreground, watches the raising of her future prison, a solitary and beautiful figure contrasted with the small figures of the distant workmen and the soldier and courtiers speaking with Acrisius. The tragedy of her coming immurement is heightened by the tension between the two regions of the painting, the garden with its exquisite flowers and the palace courtyard, through whose iron-studded gate she must soon be taken to a life bereft of freedom and human company. (*Culture and Sport Glasgow [Museums]: Danaë and the Brazen Tower, Edmund Burne-Jones*)



Closer Look

Two Romantic Idealists

Gustave Moreau (1826–1898) and Edward Burne-Jones (1833–1898) were profoundly inspired by classical mythology, and their art goes far beyond the morality and symbolism of many of their contemporaries. Moreau's great paintings *Prometheus*, *Oedipus*, and *Heracles* probe the meaning of the classical texts and express a heroic humanism appropriate for the challenges of his time. In England, Burne-Jones, who shared with William Morris the ideals of the Pre-Raphaelite movement, returned again and again to the classical myths to support his search for purity and beauty in the past. In *Danaë and the Brazen Tower* (1888), he focuses on Danaë's feelings as the tower is built, not on the lust of Zeus and the anger of Acrisius. In the *Pygmalion Series* (1878) and the *Perseus Series* (1887), Burne-Jones turns from the anger of the gods and the violence of the hero to the ideals of piety, chivalry, and chaste love. These very ideals involve the psychological and sexual tensions that Freud (1856–1939) at the same time was beginning to explore.

helper. Since the Gorgon's head was an attribute of Athena's aegis, she may very early have been associated with the saga, for much of the literary tradition was in the hands of Athenians.³ Pindar, writing in the first half of the fifth century B.C., makes Athena the sole helper: "Breathing courage, Danaë's son joined the company of blessed men, and Athena was his guide" (*Pythian Odes* 10. 44–46).

The Graeae

Advised by Hermes and Athena, Perseus made his way to the three daughters of Phorcys, sisters of the Gorgons and old women (in Greek, the *Graiai*) from their birth. They alone could tell Perseus the way to some nymphs who possessed the magic objects he would need for his task, but they would part with their information only under duress. Among them they had one eye and one tooth, which they passed to one another in turn. Perseus got hold of both eye and tooth and gave them back only when the Graeae had told him the way to the nymphs. From the nymphs he received three objects: a **Cap of Invisibility**, a pair of **winged sandals**, and a **wallet** or **kibisis**.⁴ From Hermes he received a **scimitar**, the only object given directly by Hermes.⁵

The Gorgons

Perseus now flew to the Gorgons, whose home was somewhere on the edge of the world, usually situated in North Africa.⁶ Pindar, who makes Perseus go to the far north, gives a beautiful description of the perfect life lived by the Hyperboreans. His account is one of the few continuous passages in extant classical Greek literature that deals with the legend of Perseus (*Pythian Odes* 10. 29–48):

Not with ships nor on foot would you find the marvelous road to the assembly of the Hyperboreans. Once did Prince Perseus feast among them when he



entered their palace; he found them solemnly sacrificing one hundred donkeys to their god. In their feasts continually and in their hymns Apollo especially takes delight, and he laughs as he sees the pride of the animals rearing up. The Muse is always with them and is a part of their customs: everywhere are the maidens' dances, the music of lyres and of the deep-sounding flutes. They bind their hair with golden laurel-wreaths, feasting with joy. Neither disease nor wasting old age has any part in their holy nation. Without labor, without battles, they live, escaping the severe justice of Nemesis. Breathing courage, Danaë's son joined the company of blessed men, and Athena was his guide. And he slew the Gorgon and came bearing the head with hair of writhing snakes, for the islanders a stony death.

The three Gorgons, of whom only **Medusa** was mortal, were of terrifying aspect, and those who looked upon their faces were turned to stone.⁷ They were asleep when Perseus came; guided by Athena. Looking only at the Gorgon's reflection in his brazen shield, he beheaded Medusa and put the head in the *kibisis*. As she was beheaded, **Chrysaor (He of the Golden Sword)** and **Pegasus**, the winged horse, sprang from her body. Their father was Poseidon; Chrysaor became father of the monster Geryon, and Pegasus was prominent in the legend of Bellerophon. According to Ovid, his hoof struck Mt. Helicon and caused the fountain Hippocrene (Horse's Fountain) to gush forth, which from then on was loved by the Muses and associated with poetic inspiration.

This is not the only association of the legend of Medusa with music and poetry. Pindar, praising Midas of Akragas, winner in the competition for flute-playing at the Pythian Games, tells how Athena invented the music of the flute in imitation of the Gorgons' lament for the death of Medusa (*Pythian Odes* 12. 5–23):

Receive this garland from Delphi for glorious Midas who is the best in Greece in the art that Pallas Athena wove from the deadly lament of the impetuous Gorgons, which Perseus heard pouring from the snaky heads that could not be approached. Grievously he labored when he killed the third part of the sisters, bringing death to sea-girt Seriphos and its people. Indeed, he brought the darkness of death to the Gorgons, god-born children of Phorcys; and grievous did the son of Danaë make the banquet of Polydectes, and the long servitude of his mother and her forced love. His spoil was the head of fair-cheeked Medusa. And he, we say, was born from the shower of gold. But when the virgin Athena had delivered the hero dear to her from these labors, she made the music of the flutes with its many notes, so that with instruments she might imitate the



Medusa, by Caravaggio (1571–1610); oil on a wooden shield covered with canvas, ca. 1598. The biographer Vasari relates that a young Leonardo da Vinci had once painted a monster upon a shield. That work has been lost, but this painting, commissioned by Cardinal Francesco Maria del Monte, has been seen as Caravaggio's attempt to compete with the legacy of the great Leonardo. It is a tour de force. Though painted on a convex shield, the image itself seems to construct a concave space. The fantastical image is rendered with a startling realism. The gorgon Medusa has just been decapitated by the hero Perseus. The wound gushes with blood. The snakes are finely drawn. The face of Medusa seems frozen in the moment of recognition of what has happened. The horror of her gaze is double-edged: both instilling petrifying terror and yet itself trapped in a horrifying realization, as her eyes look down at her missing body. (*Scala/Ministero per i Beni e le Attività culturali/Art Resource, NY*)



Closer Look



Audio



Danaë and the Chest. Attic red-figure lekythos, ca. 470 B.C.; height 16 in. The infant Perseus, already in the chest, reaches up to his reluctant mother. Acrisius gestures impatiently to her to get in. In her left hand Danaë holds a perfume jar. (*The Providence Painter, Red Figure Lekythos, about 470 B.C., slip-decorated earthenware, Toledo Museum of Art, Purchased with funds from the Libbey Endowment, Gift of Edward Drummond Libbey, 1969.369. Photo Credit: Toni Marie Gonzalez, Toledo Museum of Art*)

loud-sounding lamentation that was forced from the hungry jaws of Euryale.⁸ This was the goddess's invention, but she gave it to mortals and called it "the music of many heads."

Perseus was able to fly away from Medusa's sisters unharmed, since he was wearing the Cap of Invisibility. In the original version of the saga, he probably returned directly to Seriphos and dealt with Polydectes.

Andromeda

At a very early stage, the legend of Andromeda was added to the story of Perseus' return. Andromeda was the daughter of King **Cepheus** and his queen, **Cassiopeia**. Their kingdom is variously placed in **Ethiopia** or in the Levant.⁹

Cassiopeia boasted that she was more beautiful than the Nereids. As a punishment, Poseidon flooded Cepheus' kingdom and sent a sea-monster

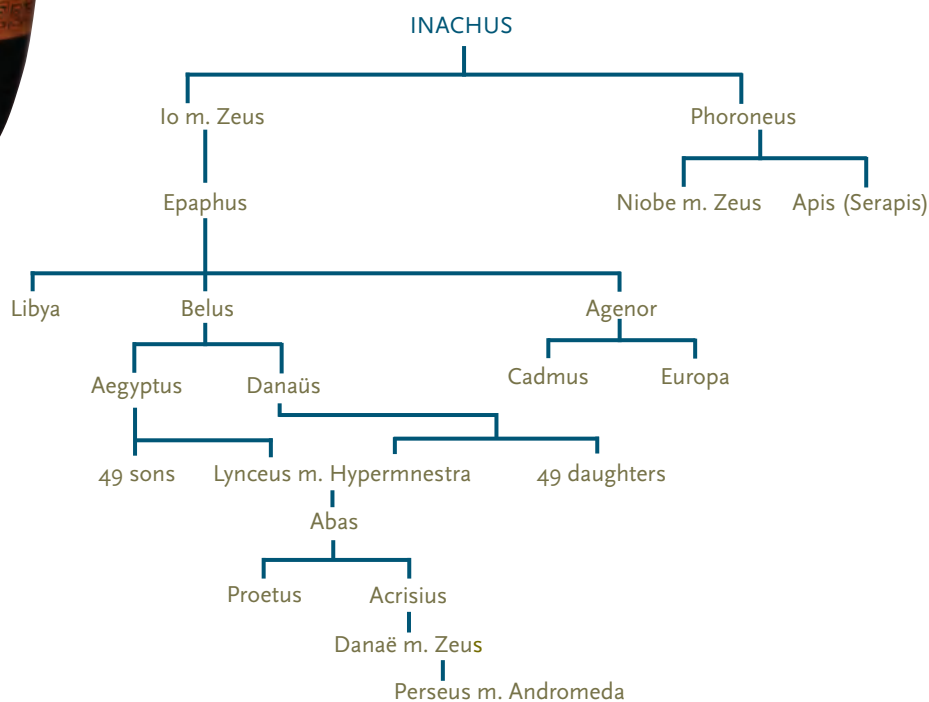


Figure 21.1 The Ancestry of Perseus

to ravage the land. Cepheus consulted the oracle of Zeus Ammon and learned that the monster could be appeased only if Andromeda were offered to it, chained to a rock. Cepheus obeyed, but at this point, Perseus came on the scene and undertook to kill the monster if he could marry Andromeda. Making use of his sandals and cap, Perseus killed the beast with Hermes' scimitar and released Andromeda, whom he married, using the Gorgon's head to deal with the opposition of Cepheus' brother **Phineus**, to whom Andromeda had previously been betrothed. After their son Perses was born, Perseus and Andromeda flew back to Seriphos, leaving Perses behind as heir to Cepheus' kingdom.

The Origin of Libyan Snakes, the Atlas Range, and Coral

A number of other details have been added to the original account of Perseus' flight with the Gorgon's head. The Gorgon's blood is said to have dripped through the *kibisis* as Perseus flew over Libya, and from the drops sprang the infinite number of poisonous snakes that (according to the belief of the ancients) infested the Libyan desert. The giant Atlas, supporter of the heavens, refused to show Perseus any hospitality, and Perseus turned him into stone with the Gorgon's head. His head and body became a mountain range, his hair the forests upon the mountains. As an example of these ingenious additions to the legend, we give Ovid's description of the creation of coral (*Metamorphoses* 4. 740–752):

Perseus washed his hands, bloody from his victory over the monster, in the sea. So that the hard sand should not damage the snake-bearing head, he made the ground soft with leaves and branches that grow beneath the sea's surface, and on these he placed the head of Medusa, daughter of Phorcys. The branch that a few moments before had been fresh and filled with living pith absorbed the monster's power; and touched by the head, its leaves and stems took on a new hardness. But the sea-nymphs tested the miraculous change on other branches and rejoiced to see the same thing happen. Now coral still retains its same nature: it grows hard in contact with air, and what in the sea was flexible becomes stone out of the water.



Perseus Beheads Medusa.

Limestone metope from Selinus, ca. 540 B.C.; height 58 in. To the left stands Athena, wearing a peplos. The winged horse, Pegasus, springs from the body of Medusa. The frontality of the figures compels the viewer to confront the horror of Medusa's face and the necessity for Perseus of avoiding her gaze. (Scala/Art Resource, NY)

10

Polydectes and Perseus' Return to Argos

When Perseus and Andromeda reached Seriphos, they found that Danaë and Dictys had taken refuge at an altar from the violence of Polydectes. Perseus displayed the Gorgon's head before Polydectes and his assembled followers, who



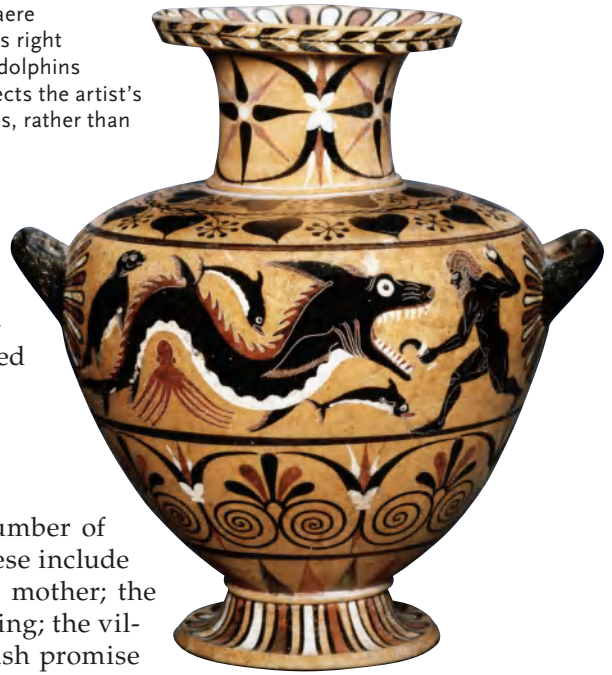
Perseus and Andromeda, by Titian (ca. 1487–1576); oil on canvas, 1554–1556, $70\frac{1}{2} \times 77\frac{3}{4}$ in. For six centuries, the subject of Andromeda has been a favorite vehicle for painters' interpretations of the theme of "Beauty and the Beast." Titian correctly gives Perseus winged sandals and *harpe*. In many versions Perseus is confused with Bellerophon and rides on the winged horse, Pegasus. (Bridgeman Art Library International—New York)

were all turned to stone. Thus Danaë was released and returned to Argos with Perseus and Andromeda. Perseus made Dictys king of Seriphos and returned the magic objects to the gods—the sandals, *kibisis*, and cap to Hermes (who returned them to the nymphs) and the Gorgon's head to Athena, who set it in the middle of her shield.

The Death of Acrisius

When Acrisius heard that Danaë's son was indeed alive and returning to Argos, he left the city and went to the city of Larissa, in Thessaly, where Perseus followed him. Here Acrisius met his long-foretold death. Competing in the athletic games that the king of Larissa was celebrating in honor of his dead father, Perseus threw a discus that accidentally killed Acrisius. He was buried outside Larissa and honored there as a hero. Perseus, having shed kindred blood, returned not to Argos but to Tiryns, whose king Megapenthes, son of Proetus,

Perseus Attacks the Sea-Monster. Etruscan black-figure hydria from Caere (Cerveteri), ca. 530 B.C.; height 15 $\frac{3}{4}$ in. Perseus brandishes a rock in his right hand and Hermes' scimitar (*harpe*) in his left. The seal, octopus, and dolphins remind the viewer of marine realities. The absence of Andromeda reflects the artist's narrative priorities, and it has been suggested that the hero is Heracles, rather than Perseus. (*Private Collection*)



exchanged kingdoms with him. As king of Tiryns, Perseus founded Mycenae, where in historical times he was honored as a hero. The children of Perseus and Andromeda became kings of Mycenae, and from them descended Heracles and Eurystheus.

Saga and Folktale

An interesting feature of the saga of Perseus is its number of folktale motifs, more than in any other Greek saga. These include the magic conception of the hero by the princess, his mother; the discovery of the hero as a child by the noise of his playing; the villainous king and his good and humble brother; the rash promise of the hero, which he performs with the aid of supernatural helpers and magic objects; the three old women from whom advice must be sought; the Gorgons, imaginary monsters of ferocious ugliness; and, finally, the vindication of the hero and the punishment of the villain. Nevertheless, Euripides found material in these tales for two tragedies, *Danaë* and *Dictys*, both of which are now largely lost.

Other Legends of Argos

The Family of Inachus

Among the earliest legends of Argos are those of the family of Inachus. The daughter of Inachus was **Io**, much of whose story is told on pages 97–99 in connection with Aeschylus' *Prometheus Bound*. Beloved by Zeus, Io was changed into a white cow by jealous Hera and guarded by all-seeing Argus until Hermes, sent by Zeus to rescue her, cut off Argus' head. Next Hera sent a gadfly to madden her; but after wandering the earth, Io came at last to Egypt, where Zeus restored her human form. There she gave birth to a son, Epaphus, destined to be the ancestor of the hero Heracles.

From other sources we learn that the Egyptians identified **Epaphus** with **Apis**, the sacred bull. His birth did not bring an end to Io's wanderings. Hera had Epaphus kidnapped, and Io set out in search of him, eventually finding him in Syria. She now returned to Egypt, where she came to be worshiped as **Isis**.

The story of Io has many confusing elements. An Apis was said to have been a son of Phoroneus and to have given the Peloponnese its ancient name of Apia; after his death he was identified with **Serapis**, who is the same as the Egyptian bull-god Apis. Io was originally a goddess; she may have been a form of Hera herself. Herodotus, who himself visited Egypt, said that Isis was identified there



Perseus, by Benvenuto Cellini (1545–1553). Cellini was a Florentine goldsmith and sculptor. This work, which stood (as it still does today) in the Loggia dei Lanzi looking out upon the Piazza della Signoria, the heart of the Florentine republic, was the product of the artist's maturity and is considered his masterpiece. It was commissioned by Cosimo de' Medici, the Duke of Florence between 1537 and 1574. Prior to this the Medici had been expelled from Florence by the republican government, but they would eventually return to power. In this work Cosimo sought to celebrate the triumph of the Medici and to underscore the threat of what would happen to their enemies. Perseus stands as the invincible hero who has just decapitated the head of Medusa. He carries the curved sword or scimitar that he received from Hermes and the winged sandals and cap of invisibility (also winged perhaps to resemble Hermes' own cap) that he received from the Graeae. The heroic figure is exalted in triumph, yet his head and eyes are turned down, both to prevent his looking upon the head but also to suggest a modesty at the apex of victory. The modeling of Perseus' body and the decorations of the plinth, which is an exquisitely wrought work of an art in itself, display the perfection of the bronzemith's art. (Sung-II Kim/Sung-II Kim/Corbis)

with Demeter, whose image Io had first brought there, and that Isis was always represented as a woman with cow's horns (in this detail being similar to the great Phoenician moon-goddess, Astarte). The versions of Io's legend vary considerably, and Aeschylus, in his two plays, the *Suppliques* and *Prometheus Bound*, gives different reasons for her departure from home and her transformation. She was originally a divine being rather than a human heroine, and through Greek contacts with the East (especially Egypt), she was assimilated into Egyptian mythology.

The Descendants of Io

Through Epaphus, Io was the founder of the royal families of Egypt and Argos, as well as those of Phoenicia, Thebes, and Crete. Epaphus himself was said to have founded many cities in Egypt, including the royal city of Memphis. His daughter was Libya, who gave her name to part of North Africa; he also had twin sons, Agenor and Belus. Agenor became the Phoenician king, father of Cadmus (founder of Thebes) and Europa (mother of the Cretan king Minos). Belus stayed in Egypt and also became the father of twin sons, Aegyptus and Danaüs, who, like their descendants Proetus and Acrisius, were bitter enemies.

The Daughters of Danaüs

Aegyptus and Danaüs quarreled over the kingdom, so that Danaüs was compelled to leave Egypt. Sailing with his fifty daughters (the **Danaïds**) via Rhodes, he came to Argos, where he peaceably established himself as king. (His subjects were called after him **Danaï**—the term by which Homer generally refers to the Greeks.) Now Aegyptus had fifty sons, who claimed as next of kin the right to marry their cousins and pursued them to Argos. Danaüs gave his daughters in marriage, but to each he gave a dagger with orders to kill her husband on the wedding night. All obeyed, save one only, **Hypermnestra**, who spared her husband, Lynceus, and hid him. As to the sequel, accounts vary. According to the most popular version, the forty-nine Danaïds who obeyed their father were punished in the Underworld by eternally having to fill water jars, through which the water leaked away.



The Baleful Head, by Edward Burne-Jones (1833–1898); oil on canvas, 1887, 60 ½ × 50 ¾ in. This is the final painting in Burne-Jones' Perseus cycle, undertaken for Arthur Balfour in 1875 and based on William Morris' poem "The Doom of Acrisius" in *The Earthly Paradise*. Ten full-scale watercolor cartoons (now in Southampton, England) and four oil paintings (now in Stuttgart, Germany) were completed. Burne-Jones sets the lovers in an enclosed garden. They look at the reflection of the Gorgon's head, held up by Perseus, in the surface of a marble-sided well. The bright, open eyes of Andromeda provide a dramatic contrast to the reflection of Medusa's closed eyes. The scene is an intense yet peaceful close to the turbulent adventures of Perseus, who still must face the battle with Phineus. (Staatsgalerie Stuttgart © Foto: Staatsgalerie Stuttgart)

According to Pindar, however, Danaüs gave them as wives to the winners of an athletic contest. After a period of imprisonment by Danaüs, Hypermnestra was reunited with Lynceus and became the mother of Abas, father of Proetus and Acrisius. Thus the line of descent of the Argive kings from Inachus to Heracles remained unbroken.

Amymone

The Danaïd Amymone was sent by her father to search for water and came upon a satyr who attempted to seduce her. She was saved by Poseidon, who then himself lay with her and as a reward caused a spring to burst from a rock with a stroke of his trident. In historical times, the spring Amymone was still shown near Argos.

Other Argive Heroes

Important Argive heroes were the seer Melampus (p. 122) and the heroes who took part in the expedition of the Seven against Thebes. Among these heroes was Tydeus, whose son Diomedes, a leading Greek hero in the Trojan War and the last great mythical prince of Argos, was widely worshiped as a hero after his death. Pindar says that Athena gave him the immortality that she denied Tydeus.

Appendix: Bellerophon and the Chimera

The famous mythological horse Pegasus is sometimes given to Perseus, but he really belongs to Bellerophon. Here is his legend, which tells how he received, harnessed, and mounted Pegasus, and performed mighty deeds.

Bellerophon, grandson of Sisyphus, was the greatest of Corinthian heroes. His legend is told in Homer by the Lycian leader Glaucus, when he meets Diomedes in battle. It is set both in the Argolid and in Asia Minor. Bellerophon may even have been introduced into Greek legend from the East.

Bellerophon was only one of several significant heroes associated with the important city-state of **Corinth**. The Corinthian poet Eumelos identified the Homeric “Ephyra” with Corinth. Homer (*Iliad* 6. 152–159) says:

There is a city, Ephyra, in a corner of horse-rearing Argos, and there lived Sisyphus, who was the most cunning of men, Sisyphus, son of Aeolus. He was father to Glaucus, and Glaucus was father to virtuous Bellerophon, to whom the gods gave beauty and lovely manliness. But Proetus devised evil against him in his heart and drove him out from the people of Argos, since Bellerophon was a better man than he. For Zeus had made him subject to Proetus.

Originally, Ephyra was no more than a minor city in the kingdom of Argos (which includes Tiryns, normally given as the city ruled by Proetus), and its rulers, Sisyphus and his grandson Bellerophon, were minor chieftains subject to the king of Argos. By identifying Ephyra with Corinth, Eumelos magnified the status of the city and its rulers. According to Eumelos, Sisyphus became the king of Corinth (which had been founded by the son of Helios, Aeëtes) after Medea left. Others make Sisyphus the founder of Corinth. In this way, the hero Bellerophon and his exploits became famous.

Born in Corinth, he left home, perhaps because of blood-guilt after unintentionally killing a brother, and went to the court of Proetus, king of Tiryns, who purified him. There Proetus’ wife **Stheneboea** (or Antea, as Homer calls her) fell in love with him. When he rejected her, she accused him before Proetus of trying to seduce her. Proetus therefore sent Bellerophon to his wife’s father

Iobates, king of Lycia, with a sealed letter that told of Sthenoboea's accusation and asked Iobates to destroy Bellerophon. Accordingly, Iobates sent the hero on a number of dangerous expeditions (Homer, *Iliad* 6. 179–193):

First, he bid him kill the fearsome Chimera, which was of divine, not mortal, breed—a lion in its forepart with a serpent's tail and in the middle a goat, and it breathed fire. He killed it, trusting in the gods' signs. Next, he fought the mighty Solymi, and this was his most violent battle with men. Third, he slew the warrior Amazons. And as he returned, the king devised another plot against him; he chose the most valiant men in all Lycia and set them in ambush. Not one of them returned home, for gallant Bellerophon killed them all.

So when the king realized that he was truly of divine descent, he kept him there in Lycia and gave him his daughter and the half 10 of his kingdom.

Bellerophon became the father of Hippolochus (Glaucus' father) and of Isandrus, who was killed fighting the Solymi, and of a daughter, Laodamia. She was loved by Zeus and by him became the mother of Sarpedon, whom Patroclus killed at Troy. Laodamia was "killed by Artemis in anger," and Bellerophon ended his days in sorrow; "hated by the gods, he wandered over the Alean plain alone, eating out his heart and avoiding the paths of men" (Homer, *Iliad* 6. 200–202).

In Homer, Bellerophon is the hero who performs certain tasks and wins the prize of a kingdom and a princess. His tragic end, to which Homer refers in vague terms, is the theme of Euripides' tragedy *Bellerophon*, in which Bellerophon tries to mount to heaven itself and fails.

Both Euripides and Pindar introduce the winged horse **Pegasus** into the myth of Bellerophon. Poseidon gave it to him, but he could not master it, as it stood by the Corinthian spring Pirene, until Athena appeared to him in a dream and gave him a magic bridle with golden trappings (Pindar, *Olympian Odes* 13. 63–92):

Much did he labor beside the spring in his desire to harness the offspring of the snake-girdled Gorgon, until the maiden Pallas brought him the gold-accounted bridle, and quickly his dream became reality. "Are you sleeping," said she, "King, descendant of Aeolus? Come, take this charm to soothe the horse and sacrifice a white bull to your forefather Poseidon, the Tamer of Horses."

These were the words which the maiden with the dark aegis seemed to speak as he slept; he leaped to his feet and took the divine object that lay beside him. And strong Bellerophon, after all his efforts, caught the winged horse by putting the gentle charm around its mouth. Mounting it straightway, he brandished his arms, himself in armor of bronze. With it he slew the archer army of women, the Amazons, shooting them from the unpeopled bosom of the cold upper air, and he slew the fire-breathing Chimera and the Solymi. His fate I shall not mention; the ancient stalls of Zeus' stable in Olympus shelter the horse.



Bellerophon and the Chimera.

Byzantine ivory plaque, fifth century; 8 ½ × 3 ½ in. Bellerophon rides on Pegasus to the right and thrusts his lance into the lion's mouth, as the monster collapses on its front paws. Its serpent-tail twines round one of the three trees that represent the landscape setting, and the goat's head melds with another. (© The Trustees of the British Museum)

Bellerophon, then, met his end in attempting to rise too high. This theme of Euripides' *Bellerophon* is also expressed in Pindar's words (*Isthmian Odes* 7. 60–68):

If any man sets his eye on a distant target, he is too short to reach the brass-paved home of the gods. For winged Pegasus hurled his rider Bellerophon, who wished to enter the palaces of Heaven and join Zeus' company.

Euripides wrote two tragedies on Bellerophon's saga. His *Bellerophon* included the hero's fall from the heavens and ended with the announcement that Pegasus had been "harnessed to the chariot of Zeus, carrying his lightning."¹⁰ He also wrote a *Stheneboea* (now mostly lost), in which Bellerophon returned to Tiryns after his labors in Lycia and killed Stheneboea by luring her onto Pegasus and throwing her down as they flew high over the sea. For Euripides, Bellerophon's end is that of a human being who fails in a high endeavor, but originally, he must have been punished, like Tantalus and Ixion, because he abused the friendship of the gods.

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Pindar	<i>Isthmian</i> 7.60–68 <i>Nemean Ode</i> 10.1–11 <i>Olympian Ode</i> 13.63–92 <i>Pythian Ode</i> 10.29–48; 12.5–23
Ovid	<i>Metamorphoses</i> 4.740–752

Additional Sources

Aeschylus	<i>Suppliant Women</i> (legend of the daughters of Danaüs)
Apollodorus	<i>Library</i> 2.4.1–2.4.5
Herodotus	<i>History of the Persian Wars</i> 2.91

Notes

1. For Proetus and Bellerophon, see the Appendix to this chapter.
2. The Roman poet Horace (*Odes* 3. 16) changed Danaë's prison to a brazen tower, which has become the traditional version.

3. The Athenian historian Pherecydes (early fifth century B.C.) is an early authority for the saga.
4. The word *kibisis* is not Greek and in antiquity was believed to be Cypriote.
5. Hermes wears the Cap of Darkness in the Gigantomachy and is regularly portrayed with winged sandals. Athena wore the Cap of Invisibility at Troy (*Iliad* 5. 844–845).
6. It is also placed by others in the far north, among the Hyperboreans, or in the far south, among the Ethiopians.
7. For their origin, see p. 173.
8. The Gorgon Euryale is mourning for her dead sister, Medusa.
9. In the first century A.D. the marks of Andromeda's fetters were still being shown on the rocks near the city of Joppa.
10. Euripides is following Hesiod, *Theogony* 285–286.

For additional resources related to this chapter, go to www.oup.com/us/morford.



Heracles

Hercules' harsh labors assure his fame.

—BOETHIUS, *Consolation of Philosophy*, 4.7.13

HERACLES IS THE GREATEST of the Greek heroes. His legends include elements of saga and folktale,¹ while his status as man, hero, and god is controversial. In Greece, he was particularly associated with the area around Argos, with Thebes (the city of his birth), and with Trachis and **Mt. Oeta** in southern Thessaly (the place of his death and apotheosis).

Amphitryon and Alcmena

The father of Heracles was Amphitryon, son of Alcaeus and brother of the king of Mycenae, **Electryon**, whose daughter, Alcmena, became his wife. After Amphitryon accidentally killed Electryon, as punishment Amphitryon was exiled from Mycenae and came to Thebes, taking Alcmena with him. There he was purified by the Theban king, Creon, and set out to campaign against the Teleboans, a people of western Greece, who had attacked Electryon in Mycenae and killed all but one of his sons.² The expedition was successful through the treachery of Comaetho, daughter of the Teleboan king Pterelaüs. Out of love for Amphitryon she pulled from Pterelaüs' head the golden hair that guaranteed him immortality and made the Teleboans invincible.

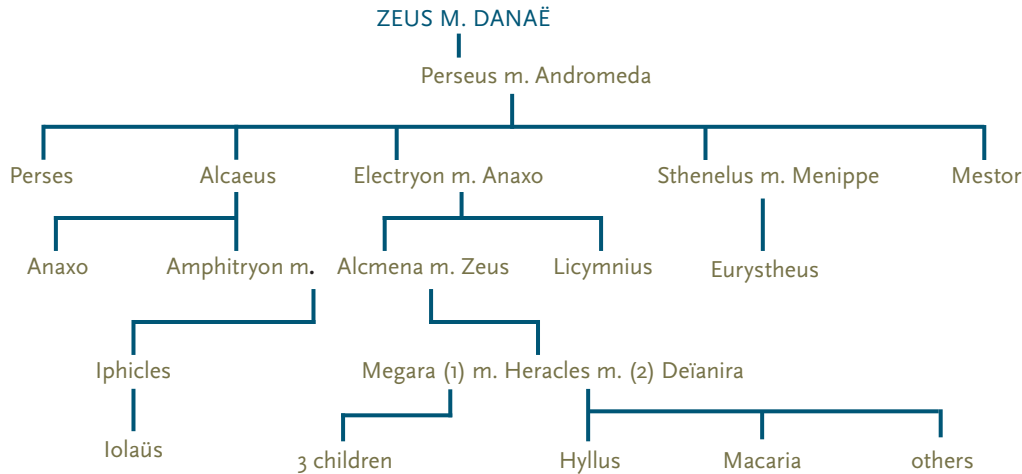


Figure 22.1 The Ancestry of Heracles

Thus Pterelaüs died and Amphitryon was victorious. Amphitryon killed Co-maetho and returned to Thebes.³

Amphitryon expected to lie with Alcmena, and he did not know that Zeus, disguised as Amphitryon, had visited her the previous night, which he extended to three times its proper length, and had told her the full story of the Teleboan expedition. Alcmena only accepted Amphitryon after Tiresias had revealed the truth. Thus Amphitryon lay “all night long with his chaste wife, delighting in the gifts of golden Aphrodite” (Hesiod, *Shield of Heracles*, 46–47). Alcmena conceived twins (it was said); the elder by one night was Heracles, son of Zeus, and the younger was Iphicles, son of Amphitryon.

In the *Amphitruo* of the Roman dramatist Plautus, Jupiter (Zeus) and Mercury (Hermes) disguise themselves as Amphitryon and Amphitryon’s servant Sosia, respectively. Amphitryon returns just after Jupiter has left Alcmena, who is thoroughly confused. She gives birth to twins, one of whom is stronger than the other and immediately strangles two serpents sent by Juno (Hera) to kill him. Just as Alcmena’s servant Bromia is describing the scene, Jupiter himself appears and reveals the truth to Amphitryon. This is the only one of Plautus’ surviving plays whose plot is taken from mythology.

The Birth of Heracles and His Early Exploits

The birth of Heracles introduces a constant feature of his story: the hostility of Hera. On the day when Heracles was to be born, Zeus had boasted on Olympus (Homer, *Iliad* 19. 103–105):

Today Eileithyia, helper in childbirth, will bring to the light a man who shall rule over all that dwell around him; he shall be of the race that is of my blood.

Hera deceived Zeus by hastening the birth of the child of Sthenelus (king of Mycenae), whose wife was seven months pregnant, and sending Eileithyia

to delay the birth of Alcmena's sons.⁴ Sthenelus was the grandson of Zeus, and so his son rather than Alcmena's fulfilled the terms of Zeus' boast. He was **Eurystheus**, for whom Heracles performed the Labors.

Pindar tells the story (mentioned earlier in connection with the *Amphitruo* of Plautus) that Hera also sent a pair of snakes to kill the infant Heracles, whose birth she had not been able to prevent. The passage ends with the prophet Tiresias foretelling the hero's part in the battle of the gods against the Giants and his eventual deification (*Nemean Odes* 1. 33–72):



Audio

Willingly do I take hold of Heracles upon the high peaks of Virtue as I retell an ancient tale. When the son of Zeus had escaped from the birth pangs with his twin and had come into the bright light, he was wrapped in the yellow swaddling bands, and Hera of the golden throne saw him. Straightway in hasty anger, the queen of the gods sent snakes, which passed through the open doors into the farthest part of the wide room, eager to coil their quick jaws around the children. But Heracles lifted up his head and for the first time made trial of battle; with his two hands, from which there was no escape, he seized by their necks the two serpents, and his grip squeezed the life out of the huge monsters, strangling them. (33–47)

10

Then fear unbearable struck the women who were helping Alcmena at the birth. Alcmena, too, leaped to her feet from the bedclothes, unclothed as she was, as if to protect her babies from the attack of the beasts. Then the Theban leaders quickly ran and assembled with their bronze weapons, and Amphitryon came, smitten with the bitter pangs of anxiety and brandishing his sword unsheathed. . . . He stood with amazement hard to bear mixed with joy, for he saw the immeasurable spirit and power of his son. The immortals indeed had made the words of the messengers untrue. Then he summoned Tiresias, his neighbor, excellent mouthpiece of Zeus the most high. To Amphitryon and to all his armed men he foretold with what fortunes Heracles would meet, how many lawless wild beasts he would kill on the sea, how many on land. He foretold how Heracles would give to his fate the man who walks with crooked insolence, most hateful of men. For, he foretold, when the gods should do battle with the giants on the plain of Phlegra, beneath the onrush of his missiles, bright hair would be soiled in the dust. But Heracles himself, in peace for all time without end, would win rest as the choice reward for his great labors, and in the palaces of the blessed he would take Hebe to be his youthful bride. Feasting at his wedding beside Zeus, son of Cronus, he would praise the holy customs of the gods. (48–72)

20

Thus Heracles survived. In his education, he was taught chariot driving by Amphitryon, wrestling by Autolycus, archery by Eurytus, and music by Linus.⁵ Heracles killed Linus, who was a son of Apollo, by striking him with his lyre, and for this was sent away to the Theban pastures on Mt. Cithaeron, where he performed a number of exploits. He killed a lion that was preying on the cattle of Amphitryon and of Thespius, king of the Boeotian town of Thespieae. During the hunt for the lion, Heracles was entertained for fifty days by Thespius and lay with one of his fifty daughters each night (or with all fifty in the same night). He also freed the Thebans from paying tribute to the Minyans of Orchomenus, leading the Theban army himself into battle. In gratitude, Creon gave him his daughter Megara as wife, and by her he had three children.



The Labors of Heracles. The first six Labors (athloi) all take place within the Peloponnese (map inset). The last six Labors take place outside of the Peloponnese throughout the Mediterranean; of these, the last three occur in the farthest western reaches of the known world.

To explore an interactive version of this map, please go to www.oup/us/morford

The Madness of Heracles

Some time later, Hera brought about a fit of madness in which Heracles killed **Megara** and her children. When he recovered his sanity, he left Thebes and went first to Thespieae, where Thespius purified him, and then to Delphi, where he sought further advice. Here the priestess of Apollo called him Heracles for the first time (until then he had been known as Alcides) and told him to go to Tiryns and there for twelve years serve Eurystheus, performing the labors that he would impose. If he did them, she said, he would become immortal.

This is the simplest story of the origin of the Labors; there is, however, great confusion over the chronology of Heracles' legends. Euripides in his *Heracles* puts the murder of Megara and her children after the Labors. Sophocles in his *Trachiniae* has Heracles marry his second wife Deianira before the Labors, whereas Apollodorus places the marriage after them. All are agreed that for a number of years Heracles served Eurystheus. Heracles' ghost says to Odysseus: "I was a son of Zeus, but infinite was my suffering; for I was slave to a far inferior mortal, and heavy were the labors he laid upon me" (Homer, *Odyssey* 11. 620–622).

The Twelve Labors

The Greek word for labors is **athloi**, which really means contests undertaken for a prize. In Heracles' case, the prize was immortality, and at least three of his Labors are really conquests of death.⁶ Heracles did not always perform the Labors unaided; sometimes Athena helped him, sometimes his nephew, **Iolaüs**. The first six Labors all take place in the northern Peloponnese, the remaining six in different parts of the world. In these last six labors, Heracles has changed from a local hero into the benefactor of all humankind. The list of the labors varies, but the twelve given are traditional and were represented on the metopes of the temple of Zeus at Olympia (see pp. 562–563).

The Peloponnesian Labors

1. The Nemean Lion Heracles was required to bring the skin of this beast to Eurystheus. Heracles killed it with a club that he had himself cut. Theocritus (in his twenty-fifth *Idyll*) makes the lion invulnerable, and Heracles has to strangle it and then flay it by using its own claws to cut its hide. The club and lionskin henceforth were Heracles' weapon and clothing and are his attributes in art and literature.

2. The Lernaean Hydra This serpent lived in the swamps of Lerna, near Argos. It had nine heads, eight of which were mortal and the ninth immortal. Each time Heracles clubbed a head off, two grew in its place. The labor was made the more difficult by a huge crab, which Hera sent to aid the Hydra. First, Heracles killed this monster, and then he killed the Hydra, helped by his nephew, Iolaüs, son of Iphicles. Each time he removed one of the heads, Iolaüs cauterized the stump with a burning brand so that another could not grow. Heracles buried the immortal head under a huge rock. He then dipped his arrows in the Hydra's poison. As for the crab, Hera took it and made it into the constellation Cancer.

3. The Cerynean Hind The hind had golden horns and was sacred to Artemis; it took its name from Mt. Cerynea in Arcadia.⁷ It was harmless, nor might it be harmed without incurring Artemis' wrath. After pursuing it for a year, Heracles caught it by the river Ladon and carried it back to Eurystheus. On the way, Artemis met him and claimed her sacred animal, but she was appeased when Heracles laid the blame on Eurystheus.

This version of the story is entirely set in the Peloponnese. A different account, however, is given by Pindar in his beautiful third *Olympian Ode*. In this version, Heracles went to the land of the Hyperboreans in the far north in search of the hind, on whose golden horns the nymph Taygete, a daughter of Atlas, had stamped the name of Artemis.⁸ Pindar's narrative allows us to connect this labor with that of the Apples of the Hesperides, for in the latter story Heracles goes to the limits of the world in search of a miraculous golden object, and again Ladon (in the form of a dragon) and Atlas appear.⁹ The labor of the Apples of the Hesperides is a conquest of death, and apparently the story of the Cerynean stag is another version of the same theme.

4. The Erymanthian Boar This destructive animal had to be brought back alive from Mt. Erymanthus. Heracles chased the boar into deep snow and there trapped it with nets. He brought it back to Eurystheus, who cowered in terror in a large jar.

This labor resulted in a side adventure (or *parergon*).¹⁰ On his way to the chase, Heracles was entertained by the centaur Pholus, who set before him a jar of wine that belonged to all the centaurs in common. When it was opened, the other centaurs, attracted by its fragrance, attacked Heracles, who repelled and pursued them. Most of them were scattered all over Greece, but Chiron was wounded by one of Heracles' poisoned arrows. Since he was immortal and could not die, he suffered incurable agonies until Prometheus interceded with Zeus and took upon himself the immortality of Chiron. Pholus also met his death when he accidentally dropped a poisoned arrow on his foot.

5. The Augean Stables Augeas, son of Helius (the Sun) and king of Elis, owned vast herds of cattle whose stables had never been cleaned out. Heracles was commanded by Eurystheus to perform the task and successfully completed it within one day by diverting the rivers Alpheus and Peneus so that they flowed through the stables. Augeas agreed to give Heracles one-tenth of his herds as a reward but then refused to keep his promise and expelled both Heracles and his own son Phyleus (who had taken Heracles' part in the quarrel). Heracles was received by a nearby prince, Dexamenus (whose name, indeed, means "the receiver"), whose daughter he saved from the centaur Eurytion. After he had finished the Labors, Heracles returned to Elis at the head of an army, took the city, and killed Augeas, making Phyleus king in his place.

It was after this expedition that Heracles was said to have instituted the Olympic Games, the greatest of Greek festivals, held every four years in honor of Zeus. He marked out the stadium by pacing it out himself, and he fetched an olive tree from the land of the Hyperboreans to be, as Pindar described it, "a shade for the sacred precinct and a crown of glory for men" (*Olympian Odes* 3. 16–18), for at that time there were no trees at Olympia, and at the games the victors were awarded a garland of olive leaves.¹¹

6. The Stymphalian Birds Heracles was required to shoot these creatures, which flocked together in a wood by the Arcadian lake Stymphalus. He flushed them out by clashing brazen castanets that Athena had given him, and then he shot them.¹²



Hercules and the Lernaean Hydra, by Gustave Moreau (1826–1898); oil on canvas, 1869–1876, 70 $\frac{1}{2}$ $\times$ 60 $\frac{1}{4}$ in. Moreau, who painted several of Hercules' Labors, devoted enormous effort to this painting. Hercules is young and of normal human size and anatomy. He stands in the attitude (legs reversed) of the *Apollo Belvedere* (p. 268), with his attributes of lionskin, bow (also Apollo's weapon), and club. The seven-headed Hydra towers over the hero, and in front of it lie the remains of its victims. The rocky cliffs heighten the drama, a suitable setting for the fearless hero. The conquest of the Hydra had long been a parable for the triumph of good government over disorder, but Moreau focuses on the moral stature of the hero rather than on political allegory. (*Gustave Moreau, French, 1826–1898, Hercules and the Lernaean Hydra, 1875/76, Oil on canvas, 179.3 x 154 cm, Gift of Mrs. Eugene A. Davidson, 1964.231, The Art Institute of Chicago; Photography © The Art Institute of Chicago*)



Closer Look

The Non-Peloponnesian Labors

7. The Cretan Bull This bull was one that Minos had refused to sacrifice to Poseidon. Heracles caught it and brought it back alive to Eurystheus. It was then turned loose and eventually came to Marathon, where in time Theseus caught and sacrificed it.

8. The Mares of Diomedes Diomedes, son of Ares, was a Thracian king who owned a herd of mares that were fed human flesh. Heracles, either alone or with an army, gained possession of them and tamed them by feeding them Diomedes himself. He took them back to Argos, where Eurystheus set them free and dedicated them to Hera. On his way to Thrace, Heracles was entertained by **Admetus**, king of Pherae, who disguised his grief at the recent death of his wife, **Alcestis**. Heracles discovered the truth and himself wrestled with Thanatos (Death), forcing Thanatos to give up Alcestis, whom he restored to her husband (see p. 266).

9. The Girdle of Hippolyta Hippolyta was queen of the Amazons, the warrior women who lived at the northern limits of the world. Heracles was sent to fetch her girdle, which had magical powers. He killed Hippolyta in battle and took the girdle. In historical times, it was displayed at Argos.

While returning from this labor, Heracles came to Troy and there rescued Hesione from the sea-monster (see p. 474). Cheated by King Laomedon of his reward, Heracles returned later (after his time as the servant of Omphale) with

Melampus and the Cattle of Phylacus

The myth of Melampus is like the tenth Labor of Heracles. He must bring back cattle from a distant place guarded, like Geryon's Erythia or Hades itself, by a dog. Like Heracles, Melampus is the bringer of cattle and even the conqueror of death itself.¹³

Bias, the son of Amythaon, was a suitor for the hand of Pero, the daughter of Neleus, for whom the bride-price was the cattle of Phylacus, the king of Phylace (in Phthia). He appealed to his brother Melampus for help, and Melampus agreed to get the cattle, even though he knew he would have to spend a year in prison at Phylace. The cattle were guarded by a monstrous dog, and Melampus was caught in the act of stealing them and so was imprisoned. After nearly a year, he heard two woodworms saying to each other that they had very nearly finished gnawing through the roofbeams of the cell. He insisted on being moved to another cell, and shortly afterward the first cell collapsed. Phylacus then set Melampus free and asked him how to cure the impotence of his son Iphiclus. Melampus agreed to tell him on condition that he be given the cattle. He sacrificed a pair of bulls, and from a vulture that was feeding on their flesh, he learned that Iphiclus' debility was the result of being frightened as a child while watching his father gelding some rams. On that occasion, Phylacus had stuck the knife, still bloody, into an oak tree, and the tree's bark by now covered it over. If it could be found and the rust from its blade scraped off and put in Iphiclus' drink for ten days, his impotence would cease. All this came to pass and Iphiclus became the father of two sons, Podarces and Protesilaüs. Melampus was given the cattle, which he drove back to Pylos and handed over to Neleus. In return, he got Pero and gave her to Bias. See also the box on p. 122.

The Temple of Zeus at Olympia and Its Sculptural Program

By the time the Olympic Games were reorganized in 776 B.C., it was commonly believed that Heracles had been their original founder in the legendary past. Construction on the Doric temple of Zeus at Olympia was begun ca. 472 and completed ca. 456 B.C. (See pp. 118–121 for a fuller discussion of the temple and its decorative program.) It is significant that this temple represents one of the first major building programs since the invasion of the Persians earlier in the century. Pausanias, the second-century A.D. travel writer, in his *Description of Greece* (5.7 ff.), describes the sanctuary and the temple, including its decoration. According to Pausanias, on the eastern and western facades, the Doric frieze included twelve metopes detailing the twelve *athloi* (labors) of Heracles that he completed in service to King Eurystheus. Pausanias describes them in the order he saw them: on the front of the temple (the eastern side), arranged from left to right: the Erymanthian Boar (7), the Mares of Diomedes (8), the Cattle of Geryon (9), the Apples of the Hesperides (10), and the Augean Stables (12); on the back (western side), apparently to be read from right to left: the Nemean Lion (1), the Lernaean Hydra (2), the Stympthalian Birds (3), the Cretan Bull (4), the Cerynean Hind (5), and the Girdle of Hippolyta (6). The omission of Cerberus (11) in Pausanias' account seems an accident; it most likely should be included among the metopes on the front, between the Apples of the Hesperides and the Augean Stables. The order of the labors does not strictly follow the arrangement of Peloponnesian and non-Peloponnesian Labors as we present it in this chapter. Some scholarly debate has arisen about the artistic logic of the ordering or whether this represents the original arrangement, but most scholars accept it.

Heracles, Assisted by Athena, Cleans the Augean Stables.

Marble metope over the east porch of the temple of Zeus at Olympia, ca. 460 B.C.; height 63 in. This local legend is given the place of honor as the final one of the series of the Labors of Heracles in the metopes of the temple of Zeus. Athena is helmeted and clothed in the Doric *peplos*, her left hand resting on her shield. With her spear (now missing) she directs Heracles as he labors to open (with a crowbar) the stables so that the river Alpheus can flush them clean. (*Alinari/Art Resource, NY*)





Athena, Heracles, and Atlas. Metope no. 10, high relief in marble, ca. 460 B.C.; height: 1.63 m. The original is in the Olympia Archaeological Museum. The artist has chosen to represent the moment that Atlas returns to Heracles, bringing the apples of the Hesperides. Heracles had taken up the burden of the vault of the sky while Atlas was away. A folded cushion helps Heracles support the weight. Athena, who customarily gives assistance to the greatest heroes, appears here in simple dress and not in her more usual battle garb. She offers gentle and unobtrusive aid with a supporting hand. It is a brilliant artistic stroke that the panel in its original placement beneath the pediment suggests Heracles is burdened by the weight of the temple roof. (*Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY*)



W 1. Nemean Lion



W 2. Lemean Hydra



W 3. Stymphalian Birds



W 4. Cretan Bull



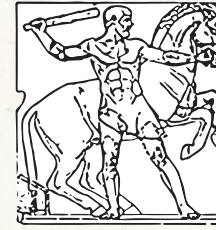
E 5. Kerynian Hind



E 6. Amazon



E 7. Erymanthian Boar



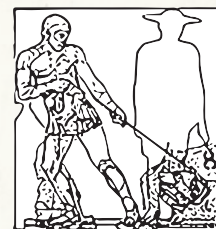
E 8. Mares of Diomedes



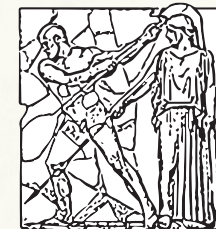
E 9. Geryon



E 10. Apples of the Hesperides



E 11. Cerberus



E 12. Augean Stables

Diagram of Olympia Metopes.

The diagram shows the arrangement of the metopes and the composition of the individual panels, though they are now in a fragmentary state. The depiction of Heracles performing his twelve Labors is completely appropriate for the temple of Zeus and the Olympic sanctuary: Heracles is a son of Zeus and the founder of the Olympic Games. He is seen here as the heroic competitor who eventually wins both immortality and immortal glory. If read correctly, the Nemean Lion is the first scene and the capture of Cerberus the last but one. It has been suggested that the Cleansing of the Augean Stables was placed last to give prominence to a local labor. The individual panels are composed of few figures and with a simplicity of design, and they vary in the precise, dramatic moment they choose to illustrate. According to scholars, it may be an aesthetic consideration that Athena in the present arrangement is depicted in the first, third, tenth, and twelfth panels.

an armed force and sacked the city, giving Hesione to his ally Telamon and leaving Podarces (Priam) on the throne of the ruined city.

10. The Cattle of Geryon The last three labors are most clearly conquests of death, with the abduction of Cerberus as their climax. Geryon lived on the island of Erythia, far away to the west. Geryon was a three-bodied monster, offspring of the Oceanid Callirhoë and Chrysaor; he tended a herd of cattle, helped by a giant herdsman, Eurytion, and a two-headed hound, Orthus (or Orthrus). Heracles' labor was to bring the cattle back to Eurystheus. To reach Erythia, Heracles was helped by Helios (the Sun), who gave him a golden cup in which to sail upon the River of Ocean, which girdles the world. He killed Orthus, Eurytion, and Geryon, and then sailed back in the cup to Tartessus (i.e., Spain) with the cattle. He returned the cup to Helios and then began to drive the cattle back to Greece.

As a monument of his journey to the western edge of the world, he set up the Pillars of Heracles at the Atlantic entrance to the Mediterranean. They are sometimes identified with the rocks of Calpe (Gibraltar) and Abyla (Ceuta), which flank the Straits of Gibraltar. In the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries these Pillars became a significant part of the political imagery of the Spanish monarchy, symbolizing the crossing of the Atlantic Ocean by Spanish explorers and traders, who returned with the wealth of the Americas to the greater glory of the monarchy. Thus, as early as 1526, Charles V had adopted the Pillars as his symbol, with the motto *Plus Ultra* ("further beyond"), and on his triumphal entry into Seville that year he was greeted as "The new Hercules, who has established the limits of the new world, just as Hercules established those of the ancient world." The imagery of the Pillars continued well into the seventeenth century, when, for example, they were prominent in the Arch of the Mint designed by Peter Paul Rubens for the Joyful Entry of the Spanish Archduke Ferdinand into Antwerp in 1535.¹⁴

Heracles' journey back to Greece has many *parerga*. While crossing the south of France, he was attacked by the tribe of the Ligurians and exhausted his supply of arrows defending himself. He prayed for help from Zeus, who sent a rain of stones that gave Heracles the ammunition he needed to drive off the attackers. He then crossed the Alps and traversed Italy, where he was said to have founded several cities.¹⁵ While Heracles was in Italy, the Italian fire god **Cacus** stole the cattle of Geryon. He killed the thief and recovered the cattle. (See pp. 674–675 for Vergil's version of this story, which he locates in Rome.)

Heracles' wanderings in Italy also took him across the strait to Sicily. There he wrestled with Eryx (king of the mountain of the same name at the western end of the island), whom he killed. He returned to Greece by traveling around the head of the Adriatic and through Dalmatia. At the Isthmus of Corinth, he killed the giant and brigand, Alcioneus. As for the cattle, Eurystheus sacrificed them to Hera.

Herodotus tells quite a different version of the legend of Geryon. In this narrative, Heracles journeyed to the cold lands beyond the Danube, and there lay with Echidna (Snake Woman), a monster who was half woman and half serpent, who bore him three sons, Agathyrus, Gelonus, and Scythes. When the three grew up, only Scythes was able to draw a bow and put on a belt that Heracles had left behind. The other two were driven away by Echidna, and Scythes became king and ancestor of the Scythians.¹⁶

11. The Apples of the Hesperides The Hesperides were the three daughters of Night, living far away to the west; they guarded a tree on which grew golden apples. The Hesperides were helped by the serpent **Ladon**, who was coiled around the tree. The apples had originally been a wedding gift from Ge to Hera when she married Zeus, and Ge put them in the garden of the Hesperides. Heracles first had to find the sea-god Nereus and learn from him the whereabouts of the garden. Nereus would tell him only after he had turned himself into many different shapes, being held all the while by Heracles. At the garden, in Euripides' version, Heracles killed Ladon and plucked the apples himself. In the tradition represented by the metopes at Olympia, however, he had the help of the Titan **Atlas**, who held up the heavens. Heracles, helped by Athena, took the heavens on his own shoulders while Atlas fetched the apples. He then returned the load to Atlas' shoulders and brought the apples back to Eurystheus. Athena is then said to have taken the apples back to the garden of the Hesperides.

This labor is a conquest of death. The apples are symbols of immortality, and the tree in the garden of the Hesperides is a kind of Tree of Life. As in the labor of Geryon, the journey to a mysterious place in the far west is really a journey to the realm of death.

On his journey to the garden of the Hesperides, Heracles killed the king of Egypt, Busiris, who would sacrifice all strangers to Zeus.¹⁷ In Libya he conquered the giant **Antaeus**, son of Ge and Poseidon, who would wrestle with those who came to his kingdom. Antaeus was invincible: every time an opponent threw him, he came in contact with his mother (Earth) and rose with renewed strength. Thus Antaeus had killed all comers and used their skulls in building a temple to his father, Poseidon. Heracles held him aloft and crushed him to death.

Some versions of this story take Heracles to the Caucasus Mountains. There he found Prometheus chained to his rock and released him after killing the eagle that tormented him (see p. 99). Prometheus advised him to use Atlas in getting the apples and foretold the battle against the Ligurians. On this occasion, too, Prometheus took over the immortality of Chiron and satisfied Zeus by letting Chiron die in his place.

12. Cerberus The final labor was to fetch Cerberus, the three-headed hound of Hades. This labor is most clearly a conquest of death, and Heracles himself (in the *Odyssey* ll. 617–626) said that it was the most difficult of the



Heracles Shows Cerberus to Eurystheus. Etruscan hydria from Caere, ca. 530 B.C.; height 17 in. The terrified Eurystheus leaps into a storage jar to escape from the Hound of Hades, which bares its three sets of teeth while its snakes furiously hiss at him. Heracles, with club and lionskin, strides forward confidently, guiding Cerberus with a leash. The humor in this splendid vase is remarkable. Compare Blake's *Cerberus* on page 370. (*Réunion des Musées Nationaux/Art Resource, NY*)

Labors and that he could not have achieved it without the aid of Hermes and Athena. In the Underworld, Heracles wrestled with Cerberus, brought him back to Eurystheus, and then returned him to Hades.

In Hades, Heracles saw Theseus and Pirithoüs, chained fast because of their attempt to carry off Persephone. He was able to release Theseus, who out of gratitude sheltered him after his madness and the murder of Megara. He also saw the ghost of Meleager, whose sister, if he still had one living, he offered to marry. Meleager named Deïanira, “upon whose neck was still the green of youth, nor did she know yet of the ways of Aphrodite, charmer of men” (Bacchylides, *Epini-cian Ode* 5. 172–175). Thus the train of events that eventually led to the death of Heracles was set in motion.

In conclusion, we translate a chorus from Euripides’ *Heracles*, which tells of the great hero’s Labors. This choral ode also reveals the nature of our sources for Greek legends, where the dry facts are enlivened by poetic expression (Euripides, *Heracles* 352–427):



Audio

I wish to offer a glorious crown for labors done, by singing the praises of him who descended into the darkness of earth’s realm of shades—whether I am to call him the son of Zeus or of Amphitryon. For the renown of noble deeds is a joy to those who have died. First, he cleared Zeus’ grove of the lion; and he wore its tawny skin upon his back, with the fearful jaws of the beast framing his fair head. (352–363)

He laid low the mountain race of savage Centaurs with his deadly arrows, slaughtering them with his winged shafts. The beautiful stream of Peneus was a witness and the vast extent of the plains without crops and the vales of Mt. Pelion and the places on the green glens of Homole—all haunts where they filled their hands with weapons of pine and, galloping as horses, brought fear to the land of the Thessalians. (364–374) 10

He slew the dappled hind with golden horns and dedicated this ravaging plunderer to the huntress Artemis of Oenoë.

He mounted the chariot of Diomedes and mastered with the bit the four mares, who ranged wild in stables drenched in blood and reveled in their horrid feasts of human flesh with ravenous jaws. (380–385)

In his labors for the king of Mycenae, he crossed over the banks of the silver-flowing Hebrus; and along the sea-cliff of Pelion, by the waters of the Amaurus, he killed with his bow Cynus, the guest-murderer who lived alone near Amphanaea. (386–393) 20

He came to the western home of the singing maidens, to pluck from amid the golden leaves the fruit of the apple, and the fiery dragon who kept guard coiled around the tree, hard even to approach, him he killed.

He made his way into the farthest corners of the sea and made them safe for men who ply the oar. (400–402)

Having come to the abode of Atlas, he extended his hand to support the vault of heaven in its midst, and by his manly strength held up the starry homes of the gods.

He crossed the swell of the Euxine Sea to the land of the Amazons, who rode in force where many rivers flow into Lake Maeotis. Mustering a band of friends from Hellas, he sought to win the gold-encrusted adornment of the warrior maid—the deadly booty of her girdle—and Hellas captured 30

the renowned prize of the foreign queen, which is kept safe in Mycenae. (408–418)

He seared the many heads of the deadly monster, the Lernaean Hydra, and dipped his arrows in its venom; with that he killed three-bodied Geryon, the herdsman of Erythia.

He won the glorious crown for these and other labors; and he sailed to the tearful realm of Hades—the final task of all. (425–427)

Other Deeds of Heracles

Cycnus, Syleus, and the Cercopes

Heracles fought and killed a number of harmful beings. Cycnus, son of Ares, used to rob men passing on their way through Thessaly to Delphi. Heracles, helped by Athena and with Iolaüs as charioteer, killed Cycnus and wounded Ares.¹⁸ Another robber was Syleus, who lived by the Straits of Euboea. Heracles destroyed his vineyard, in which Syleus compelled passers-by to work, and then killed Syleus himself.

More folktale than myth is Heracles' encounter with the Cercopes, whose home is placed in various parts of Greece or Asia Minor. They were a pair of dwarfs who spent their time playing tricks on people. They had been warned by their mother "to beware of the black-bottomed man." Now as Heracles was asleep under a tree, they attempted to steal his weapons, but he caught them and slung them from a pole across his shoulders upside down. They thus had an uninterrupted view of his backside which, since the lionskin did not cover it, had been burned black by the sun. They joked about the sight so much that Heracles, himself amused, let them go. Later they tried to trick Zeus and were punished by being turned into either apes or stones.

Hylas

Heracles was among the heroes who sailed on the *Argo*. But he was too important to be subordinate to other heroes in the saga, and so he soon dropped out of the expedition. In one version, he went looking for the boy Hylas, whom he loved. When the *Argo* put in at Cios (in Asia Minor), Hylas went to a nearby spring to draw water, and the water-nymphs were so entranced by his beauty that they pulled him into the water, to remain with them forever. Heracles spent so long searching for him that the rest of the Argonauts sailed away without him, and he returned on his own to Argos after establishing a cult of Hylas at Cios. In late antiquity, the people still searched for him annually, calling out his name.¹⁹

Military Expeditions

Heracles took part in Zeus' battle against the giants, during which he slew the terrible Alcyoneus. He attacked Laomedon, king of Troy, and Augeas, king of Elis, who had both cheated him. He made an expedition against Neleus, king of Pylos, who had refused to purify Heracles after the murder of Iphitus. He killed eleven of the twelve sons of Neleus; the twelfth, Nestor, eventually became king



Hylas and the Nymphs, by J. W. Waterhouse (1849–1917); oil on canvas, 1896, 38 × 63 in. The young Hylas is lured to his fate by seven water-nymphs. The artist brilliantly combines English Victorian ideals of female beauty and landscape (the latter in colors of great beauty) with psychological insight that anticipates Freud. (City Art Gallery, Manchester, England)



Closer Look

of Pylos and took part in the Trojan War. According to Hesiod, one of the sons of Neleus was Periclymenus, to whom Poseidon had given the ability to transform himself into every sort of bird, beast, or insect. With the help of Athena, Heracles recognized him in the form of a bee settled upon the yoke of his horse-drawn chariot and shot him with an arrow.

In this expedition also, says Homer, Heracles wounded the god Hades, “in Pylos among the corpses” (*Iliad* 5. 395–397), as if the expedition were another conquest of death. Homer also mentions that Heracles wounded Hera, and says that this was another example of Heracles’ violence—“brutal and violent man, who did not scruple to do evil and wounded the Olympian gods with his arrows” (*Iliad* 5. 403–404). This is an older view of Heracles and more likely represents the character of the original mythical hero than that of Pindar, who makes the following protest (*Olympian Odes* 9. 29–36):

How would Heracles have brandished his club with his hands against the trident, when, in defense of Pylos Poseidon pushed him back, and Apollo shook him and drove him back with his silver bow, nor did Hades keep his staff unmoved, with which he drives mortal bodies to the hollow ways of the dead? Hurl this story, my mouth, far away!

We can see that by Pindar’s time (the first half of the fifth century B.C.) the transformation of Heracles was already well advanced, from the primitive strongman into a paragon of virtue. Heracles also made an expedition